The Children's Book of John — Illustration Pilot

Brief for Nadine

Lydia du Toit

Thank you so much for the lovely work on the John-at-his-desk picture! We'd love to work with you on the illustrations for the book. Before we plan the whole book, here is a small **pilot of two pictures**, so we can see together how your style works with the new direction.

The book

The Children's Book of John — Discovering Ourselves as Loved retells the Gospel of John for readers **aged 8 and up**, inspired by the Mirror Bible. The central theme is that every reader discovers they are loved.

The illustrations should feel **timeless, playful and full of personality**: something an 8-year-old loves, a 12-year-old doesn't find babyish, and adults enjoy too. Playful without being childish, beautiful without being overly polished, and definitely not the traditional Sunday-school-Bible look.

The two pilot pictures

The two sketches in this pack (`rough-cana.png`, `rough-nicodemus.png`) were made with an AI image tool **as rough composition sketches only**. Please treat them as loose starting points for the idea, the staging and the expressions. **Change, simplify, re-compose and add your own ideas freely**: we want *your* hand-drawn picture, not a copy of the sketch.

1. The wedding at Cana (John 2), full page. Jesus turns water into wine. Rather than the usual picture of Jesus standing by the water jars, we show the *astonishment and delight* of the people: the master of the feast tasting the wine, eyes popping (in his cup he sees a little golden reflection of his own delighted face); a servant peeking from behind a big stone jar, grinning because he knows the secret; an auntie clutching her heart; a child dancing. Jesus is in the background, just one of the guests, laughing with friends.





2. Nicodemus (John 3), character portrait. An important, learned religious teacher who comes to see Jesus secretly at night. Tall, thin, long serious face, grey beard, fine robes, clutching a scroll and holding a small oil lamp. Peering out from under his hood with one eyebrow raised: curious, cautious, a bit afraid of being seen, but secretly hopeful. A real person you could know. Background minimal: mostly paper with a hint of night.

Look and feel

Palette: limited to five colours, with lots of cream paper showing:

The Children's Book of John — palette

Deep indigo	Terracotta	Sage green	Mustard	Warm cream
#2E3A6B	#C4623F	#8FA58A	#D9A93B	#F4EAD5
night, depth, mystery	warmth, clothing, earth	landscape, vines, calm	light, joy, the 'love' glow	paper, lots of white space

Please move away from the warm orange-yellow wash of the earlier pictures. Mustard is now a highlight colour for light and joy, not the overall tone.

Characters:

- Full of personality, with slightly exaggerated, quirky proportions (big noses, big hands, gangly or round, very different ages and heights). Your big-nosed John was exactly right!
- Every face different. Expressions specific to the moment (astonishment, doubt, shyness, grief, wonder), so not everyone smiling the same smile.
- Warm Middle Eastern skin tones. Setting suggested simply, not a museum reconstruction.
- **Jesus:** an ordinary, warm, very alive man in his thirties. No halo or glowing robe; approachable, often laughing or listening closely.

Recurring motifs (for the whole book, not every picture):

- *Reflection*: characters glimpsing themselves lit up, in water, a cup or someone's eyes (the Mirror Bible idea).
- A small mustard-gold glow where love is "discovered" in a scene.
- Generous white space; pictures may fade into the page instead of sitting in a hard rectangle.

Please avoid: glossy or cinematic digital painting, generic perfect faces, cute preschool style, halos, old-fashioned Sunday-school art.

Technical

- Book trim size **6 × 9 in** (portrait).
- Full-page pictures: **6.25 × 9.25 in at 300 dpi (1875 × 2775 px)**, which includes 0.125 in bleed. Keep faces and key details at least 0.5 in from the edges. Working larger is welcome.
- Portraits and small pictures: transparent background (PNG), or on the cream colour.
- Please send a flattened PNG or TIFF, plus your layered source file if possible. RGB is fine for now.
- Please add no text or lettering in the pictures.

Looking ahead: the whole book (about 20 pictures)

If the pilot works for everyone, the full set would be roughly 20 pictures. This is a draft list that we'll refine together:

- **Cover (1):** to be designed together.
- **Full-page key moments (8):** Cana · the Samaritan woman at the well · the blind man sees · Lazarus · the foot-washing · the cross (gentle, symbolic) · Mary Magdalene in the garden · breakfast on the beach.
- **Symbolic chapter openers (5):** the Word as light (John 1) · bread (6) · the Good Shepherd (10) · "my Father's house" (14) · the vine (15).
- **Character portraits (6):** John · Peter · Nicodemus · the Samaritan woman · Martha · Thomas.

For each one we'd send a similar rough sketch and brief. Maps and timelines will be done separately.

Questions for you

1. Does this direction and palette suit the way you work?

2. Roughly what would you charge per picture (full page vs. portrait), and how long does each take?
3. How would you like to be credited in the book, and are you happy to agree the usage rights in writing before publication?

Thank you, we're so excited to see what you make of it!